

Throughout the world, many children are exposed to the detrimental effects of housing insecurity, but in comparison with other European Union member states, child poverty and social exclusion indicators for the Republic of Latvia are among the highest.¹ People facing housing insecurity can meet a variety of problems such as being unable to pay rent, overcrowding, moving frequently, homelessness, and spending a large amount of household income on housing.² Housing insecurity significantly affects children because it can disrupt their education, have adverse physical and mental health effects, and disrupt a child's development at a critical time. The 1959 United Nations Declaration of the Rights of the Child (UNDRC) defines all child's rights to protection, shelter, education, and healthcare, but these can be jeopardized because of insecurity. In addition to the declaration, the 1989 Convention on the Rights of the Child guides the *United Nations Childrens Fund (UNICEF)* mission to further the rights of the child.³ Data shows that moving frequently can significantly impact a child's health, one of the rights defined in the UNDRC. If a child is born while the family is experiencing a period of housing instability, it can lower the infant's birth weight, cause respiratory problems such as asthma, a fever, and other health problems that, if left untreated, can stay with the child forever.⁴ Further, moving three or more times in early childhood, especially for low-income children, can be detrimental to a child's cognitive, mental, and emotional development.

¹ "Investing in children: Breaking the cycle of disadvantage" EU Network of Independent Experts on Social Inclusion, 2013, https://www.lm.gov.lv/sites/lm/files/data_content/lv_investing-in-children_2013_en.pdf

² "Housing Instability - Healthy People 2030" health.gov, <https://health.gov/healthypeople/priority-areas/social-determinants-health/literature-summaries/housing-in-stability>

³ "World Issues: Children" The United Nations, <https://www.un.org/en/global-issues/children#>

⁴ Robin Clark, et al., "Infants Exposed to Homelessness: Health, Health Care Use, And Health Spending From Birth To Age Six," *Health Affairs* 38, no. 5 (May 2019): 721-728, <https://doi.org/10.1377/hlthaff.2019.00090>

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This can be devastating to a child's development because 90 percent of the brain develops before the age of five and constant moving can impede brain development at such an early age.⁵ Housing insecurity, especially poverty and homelessness, also affects education. Students who move frequently and experience homelessness are twice as likely to become "chronically absent," meaning that a student is absent at least ten percent of the school year. This has been proven to result in poor academic performance, and it inhibits development which is crucial to the child.⁶

As previously stated, child poverty and social exclusion are preeminent issues children in Latvia deal with daily. This is an immense issue because as of 2019, about 19 percent of children in Latvia were at risk of poverty or social exclusion. Further, although the Latvian Ministry of Welfare regrets not developing an adequate plan to help keep children out of poverty during the COVID-19 pandemic, mitigating the fatal virus was of utmost importance. Having said this, the lack of a thorough plan further exacerbated the public health and education crisis, especially for children living in or at risk of poverty. This left the aid in the hands of non-governmental organizations (NGOs) who were overwhelmed by the increased demand for aid caused by COVID-19. This caused an abundance of issues for children in the Republic of Latvia such as an increase in "violent episodes" with families, limited access to healthcare services, educational challenges, and an increase in mental health issues.⁷

Heightened by the COVID-19 pandemic, this wide range of issues inflamed by housing insecurity can have an enduring impact on a child's life. Aggravating this, a study conducted in Canada has shown that overcrowded households have an increased risk of tuberculosis and infectious

⁵ "How Housing Matters" Kathleen Ziol-Guest and Ariel Kalil, March 2014, <https://housingmatters.urban.org/sites/default/files/wp-content/uploads/2014/09/How-Housing-Matters-Policy-Research-Brief-Frequent-Moves-in-Childhood-Can-Affect-Later-Earnings-Work-and-Education.pdf>

⁶ Meredith Fergus, et al, The Impact of Housing Insecurity on Educational Outcomes (Minnesota: Office for Higher Education, December 2019), 1-6, https://www.ohe.state.mn.us/pdf/Impact_Housing_Insecurity_&_Educational_Outcomes.pdf

⁷ "Latvia COVID-19 Crisis From a Children's Rights Perspective" Eurochild and Latvian Child Welfare Network, 2020, <https://eurochild.org/uploads/2021/02/LV-ECH-S20-profile.pdf>

diseases such as COVID-19. One of these issues is abuse which has been proven to damage a child's cognitive development which can lead to substance abuse.⁸ Further, abuse can cause a child to enter the foster care system (FCS), another form of housing insecurity. In regards to a child's risk of poverty in Latvia, although 29.4 percent of families with one adult and children are at risk of poverty, there has been a steady decline in this percentage partially due to the Republic of Latvia providing families with 500 Euros per child in 2020 to help families during the pandemic.⁹ Furthermore, the 2012 Latvian ACE study, a study measuring different types of childhood neglect, abuse, and maltreatment showed that only 16.9 percent of respondents reported not having any traumatic or adverse experiences during childhood (ages 0-14). This is further proven by a study conducted by the Ombudsman's Office which deals with human rights in Latvia. The study included 500 children in grades 5-12 and found that 47 percent of the children had experienced some form of violence in their childhood.¹⁰ Maltreatment can be exceedingly harmful to children with a high ACE score because it is linked with earlier sexual intercourse, higher odds of using drugs, and an increased risk of suicide.¹¹ Even worse, a study has found that those who have experienced at least two forms of childhood maltreatment are 180% more likely to be living below the poverty line in adulthood.¹² Finally, the University of Nevada, Las Vegas has conducted a study that shows that in low-income households that do not know how the rent will be paid, there is an increase in maltreatment. This shows that housing insecurity can have a direct impact on childhood maltreatment.¹³

⁸ "Long-term Consequences of Child Abuse and Neglect" Children's Bureau, Child Welfare Information Gateway, August 2021, https://www.childwelfare.gov/pubpdfs/long_term_consequences.pdf

⁹ "One in Five at Risk of Poverty in Latvia" eng.lsm.lv, December 27, 2022, <https://eng.lsm.lv/article/society/society/one-in-five-at-risk-of-poverty-in-latvia>

¹⁰ "Situation analysis of child maltreatment prevention in Latvia" World Health Organization, 2018, www.euro.who.int/__data/assets/pdf_file/0020/361451/child-maltreatment-prevention-Latvia-2018.pdf.

¹¹ "Adverse Childhood Experiences of Young Adults in Latvia" The Ministry of the Republic of Latvia, <https://www.spkc.gov.lv/lv/veselibu-ietekmejos-paradumu-petijumi/adverse-childhood-experiences-of-young-adults-in-latvia.-study-report-from-the-2011-survey.pdf>

¹² "Childhood Maltreatment Linked to Adulthood Economic Problems" National Institute of Health, October 2009 <https://www.nih.gov/news-events/nih-research-matters/childhood-maltreatment-linked-adulthood-economic-problems>

¹³ "Housing Insecurity and Its Risk to Child Maltreatment" UNLV, August 16 2022, <https://www.unlv.edu/news/article/housing-insecurity-and-its-risk-child-maltreatment>

Section II

In 2007, nearly 40 percent of Latvians were cost-burdened, meaning that they spent over 40 percent of their disposable income on housing costs. In 2020, only about 7 percent of people living in Latvia were cost burdened¹⁴ Although this number has decreased significantly, there is still work to be done. Studies show that communities experience a rapid increase in homelessness when a typical household spends at least 32 percent of their disposable income on rent.¹⁵ Further research has shown that the average Latvian household spends 11.8 percent of their disposable income on housing, but single-parent households on average spend 16.4 percent of their disposable income on housing.¹⁶ Furthermore, 35 out of every 10,000 Latvians are homeless, much higher than the rates of Latvia's closest neighbors and allies such as Lithuania and Estonia. From 2009 to 2017, following the Great Recession, there was a 389 percent increase in Latvia's homeless population. Part of the reason why homelessness in Latvia is high is that measures to reduce it are mainly left up to individual jurisdictions, and there is a significant amount of prejudice against homeless people preventing them from attaining healthcare and access to food and water.¹⁷ Although there is no official legislation in Latvian law that discusses homelessness, recent measures have been taken to fight homelessness by providing shelters. These actions have been beneficial to families, which helps to keep kids off the streets. Although the Republic of Latvia has made progress in providing shelters for people facing homelessness, no progress has been made to provide affordable housing. Although long-term solutions have not yet been made to transition people from off the streets and out of shelters to living in affordable housing and working, there has been a decrease in the number of children who are

¹⁴ "Republic of Latvia: 2022 Article IV Consultation-Press Release and Staff Report" International Monetary Fund. European Dept., August 23 2022,
<https://www.elibrary.imf.org/view/journals/002/2022/277/002.2022.issue-277-en.xml>

¹⁵ "New Research Quantifies the Link Between Housing Affordability and Homelessness" National Alliance to End Homelessness, December 13 2018,
<https://endhomelessness.org/blog/new-research-quantifies-link-housing-affordability-homelessness/>

¹⁶ "20% of Latvians found housing costs a burden in 2020" eng.lsm.lv, March 2 2021,
<https://eng.lsm.lv/article/society/society/20-of-latvians-found-housing-costs-a-burden-in-2020.a395023/>

¹⁷ "Examining Homelessness in Latvia" The Borgen Project, September 24, 2020,
<https://borgenproject.org/homelessness-in-latvia/>

homeless. This is likely because the Ministry of Welfare has provided targeted relief to families to lower the number of children facing homelessness, especially in the capital, Riga.¹⁸ In recent years, social services in Latvia have included day shelters for families and extra support for orphaned children and those living with non-family members. This indicates that Latvia is making progress because child poverty reduction has never historically been a priority. Furthermore, in normative acts, children are identified as a priority group to receive special support services, but requirements such as adequate healthcare and housing are often not met. A first step for Latvia would be to address inadequate housing supply and poor housing quality in future country reports.

Additionally, the number of kids in care institutions has been gradually declining, but this number remains very high. Care institutions can cause children to suffer from structural neglect, which includes minimal resources and inadequate social-emotional interactions between caregivers and children. This can lead to malnourishment and cause children to have “post-institutional syndrome” which has the potential to negatively impact or delay their physical, hormonal, cognitive, and emotional development.¹⁹

Although 70 percent of households in Latvia own their house outright, which allows for greater housing stability, most of the purchases were made during the Soviet era, so many of these homes are in poor condition. This is extremely problematic because studies have shown that children living in low-income households are more developmentally harmed from poor housing quality than residential instability (constant moving) or affordability issues.²⁰ Even worse, over one-third of households live in overcrowded dwellings, which is the highest percentage of any OECD member.²¹

¹⁸ “National strategies to fight homelessness and housing exclusion” European Social Policy Network, 2019, <https://ec.europa.eu/social/main.jsp?catId=738&langId=en&pubId=8243&furtherPubs=yes>

¹⁹ “Children in Institutional Care: Delayed Development and Resilience” National Library of Medicine, August 12, 2014, <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4130248>

²⁰ “How Housing Quality Affects Child Mental Health” Housing Matters Urban Institute, Will Schuppman, October 26 2017, <http://housingmatters.urban.org/articles/how-housing-quality-affects-child-mental-health>

²¹ “Policy Actions for Affordable Housing in Latvia” Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development, June 17 2020, https://issuu.com/oecd.publishing/docs/latvia_housing_report_web-1

Further, a study was conducted that tracked children in rural areas who faced poor living conditions such as overcrowding, clutter, and hazards in the dwelling beginning at age 9. The study found that after fifteen years of living in these poor conditions, children had worse psychological health and they had feelings of helplessness. This is a major problem in Latvia because of the very high number of households that live in poor conditions or in overcrowded dwellings (over half of all children live in overcrowded dwellings throughout Latvia).²²

The Republic of Latvia has yet to formally make the reduction of a child's risk of poverty a targeted priority, but the government has launched campaigns to lower poverty numbers. However, the National Reform Programme of Latvia (NRP) (also referred to as the "Europe 2020" strategy) aims to reduce poverty index numbers for the whole population to 21 percent, but this does not specifically target children. Alternatively, the NRP does target the reduction of child poverty differently by aiming to reduce labor force taxes, ensuring the accessibility of free primary and secondary education, and reducing income inequality. Furthermore, Latvia's guaranteed minimum income (GMI) benefits have been increased by fifteen percent for families with children who have not.²³ Latvia has been very successful with lowering at-risk-of-poverty-or-social-exclusion (AROPE) levels by aggressively following the Europe 2020 strategy, but two-thirds of nations have not. Latvia urges other European Nation members to actively follow the Europe 2020 strategy.

Section III

To lessen the impacts of housing insecurity on all children, it is necessary to provide affordable housing to families. Article 96 of the Latvian Constitution states that every child shall have the right to housing. Additionally, Latvia has signed many binding international treaties and agreements such as the European Social Charter to provide adequate housing, lower housing costs,

²² "Housing and neighborhood physical quality: Children's mental health and motivation" ScienceDirect, June 2017, <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S027249441730004X>

²³ "PROGRESS REPORT ON THE IMPLEMENTATION OF THE NATIONAL REFORM PROGRAMME OF LATVIA WITHIN THE "EUROPE 2020" STRATEGY" Various Latvian Ministries, April 2013, https://commission.europa.eu/system/files/2017-02/nrp2013_latvia_en_0.pdf

and reduce homelessness.²⁴ One measure the Latvian government is taking is providing a mortgage guarantee to households with children. This legislation has been shown to benefit higher-income households the most because they have the income to support the mortgage²⁵ The Delegation of Latvia believes there should be housing support for families that do not qualify for a mortgage through government grants. These grants could go to families who are beginning to enter the labor force but do not yet have the means to purchase a home suitable for their family and single-parent households as they are significantly disadvantaged by housing insecurity because they are at a higher risk of poverty than dual-income households. The grants must have restrictions on the size of the house based on family size and whether the parent is part of the labor force. Families would apply through an updated page on the Latvia Portal of State Administration Services website. The eligibility requirements would be determined by Latvia's GMI benefit criteria and new criteria to include the "missing middle." Applications would be reviewed by municipal social service offices. Any member of the family can file a claim, but there should be proof that you are entering the workforce if you are a dual-income household. Additionally, there shall be support services available to families that are not yet working to help them find jobs. Latvia also has a social housing unit which is controlled by local housing municipalities and the Ministry of Regional Development. The social houses and apartments are municipally owned and local authorities are responsible for funding the social housing, although partnerships with the private sector are encouraged. Latvia has one of the lowest amounts of social housing stock in the OECD.²⁶ Additionally, housing allowances are very low; a family with a single earner and two children would receive about seven percent of their gross earnings for a housing allowance, which is less than half of the average received in other OECD

²⁴ "State of Housing Rights in Latvia" Housing Rights Watch, November 4th 2015, <https://www.housingrightswatch.org/page/state-housing-rights-latvia>

²⁵ "Policy Actions for Affordable Housing in Latvia" Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development, June 17 2020, https://issuu.com/oecd.publishing/docs/latvia_housing_report_web-1

²⁶ "Social Housing in Europe - Latvia" Housing Europe, March 27 2010, <https://www.housingeurope.eu/resource-113/social-housing-in-europe>

countries. Not only are the social housing stock and allowances minimal, but they also leave out the homeless population and the households that cannot afford mortgages but are not disadvantaged enough to qualify for social housing (the “missing middle”). Further, the Republic of Latvia has yet to create a formal plan to combat homelessness, so developing a specific plan to reduce homelessness in the nation should be a top priority of the government. The Delegation of Latvia believes Latvia should leverage funds from the European Commission’s Affordable Housing Initiative to create more social housing, refurbish existing social dwellings, and fund the grants.²⁷

Since a big problem in Latvia is the quality of housing as opposed to the availability of housing, it is in the country's best interest to “refurbish” homes rather than build new ones. Ten percent of children in Latvia have self-reported not having access to basic facilities, which is a very high number in comparison to other OECD members, showing the poor quality of housing in Latvia. It is important to note that there is a similar housing situation in the two other Baltic Region nations. A nationwide survey should be conducted to find out which residential dwellings are in poor condition and who needs access to government aid services. After the survey is completed, we feel as if the government should partner with the private sector to improve the already existing properties. The amount of aid a household receives should be based on criteria close to what is used by the EU.

In addition, we believe there should be an expansion in rent allowances to 1, allow for “missing middle” households to benefit while also remaining in the workforce, and 2, allow for necessary home refurbishment to take place by partially paying for the construction costs. The Delegation of Latvia understands the value of education on a child’s emotional and physical development and thus believes that families whose kids attend school at least ninety percent of the time should receive additional benefits, especially remittances for construction and rent.

²⁷ “Internal Market, Industry, Entrepreneurship and SMEs” European Commission, https://single-market-economy.ec.europa.eu/sectors/proximity-and-social-economy/social-economy-eu/affordable-housing-initiative_en

Finally, there have been very few initiatives by the private or public sectors to promote parenting education in Latvia.²⁸ Parenting education is important because improving parenting skills enhances a child's well-being. Although Latvia has created the Latvian National Development Plan 2021-2027 to provide parenting education we feel that it is still inadequate because these measures are mainly in Urban areas. This leaves out the parents in rural areas where parenting education may be needed the most. We think that if there have been any reports of abuse or a child has been chronically absent from school, parenting classes should be required to receive housing assistance. We believe that with collaboration between the private and public sectors, increased social housing and allowances, a partnership between education and housing, and an increased effort to provide affordable housing, housing insecurity can be reduced for children living in the Republic of Latvia.

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²⁸ "Information on Child and Family Policy in Latvia" United Nations, <https://www.un.org/development/desa/family/wp-content/uploads/sites/23/2020/08/Latvia.pdf>

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